PassFrame
TUITION

The King Who Burned the Cakes

Year 4 — 11+ Lesson Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (History)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

More than a thousand years ago, England was threatened by fierce invaders called the Vikings. The king at the time was a clever and determined man named Alfred, who ruled the kingdom of Wessex. For a while, things went so badly for Alfred's army that he was forced into hiding in the marshes of Somerset, disguised as an ordinary traveller so that nobody would recognise him as a king.

One cold evening, tired and hungry, Alfred came to the small cottage of a peasant woman. Not knowing who her guest really was, she agreed to let him shelter by her fire, on one condition: he must watch her cakes while she went out to fetch water, and make sure they did not burn.

Alfred sat by the warm hearth, but his mind was far away, worrying about battles and strategies for defeating the Vikings. Before he knew it, smoke was curling up from the hearth — the cakes had burned black.

When the woman returned, she was furious. 'You lazy good-for-nothing!' she scolded, not realising she was shouting at her king. 'You were happy enough to eat them, but you couldn't be bothered to watch them!'

Alfred said nothing except a quiet apology. Not long afterwards, he gathered his strength, rallied his soldiers, and went on to defeat the Vikings in a great battle — proving that even a king can learn something from a burnt cake.

Questions

20 min · 12 questions

1. What was the name of the invaders threatening England in this story?

2. Why was King Alfred hiding, disguised as an ordinary traveller?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you what job the woman gave Alfred to do.

4. Underline the sentence that shows Alfred was not paying attention to the cakes.

5. What does “disguised” mean as it is used in the extract?

6. True or false: the woman knew she was talking to the king.

7. Why do you think Alfred's mind was “far away” while he sat by the fire?

8. What happened to the cakes while Alfred was thinking?

9. In your own words, explain why the woman was so angry with Alfred.

10. What does this story suggest about how people believed kings should behave?

11. Why do you think Alfred only gave “a quiet apology” instead of revealing who he was?

12. Do you think this story is trying to teach a lesson? If so, what do you think it is?